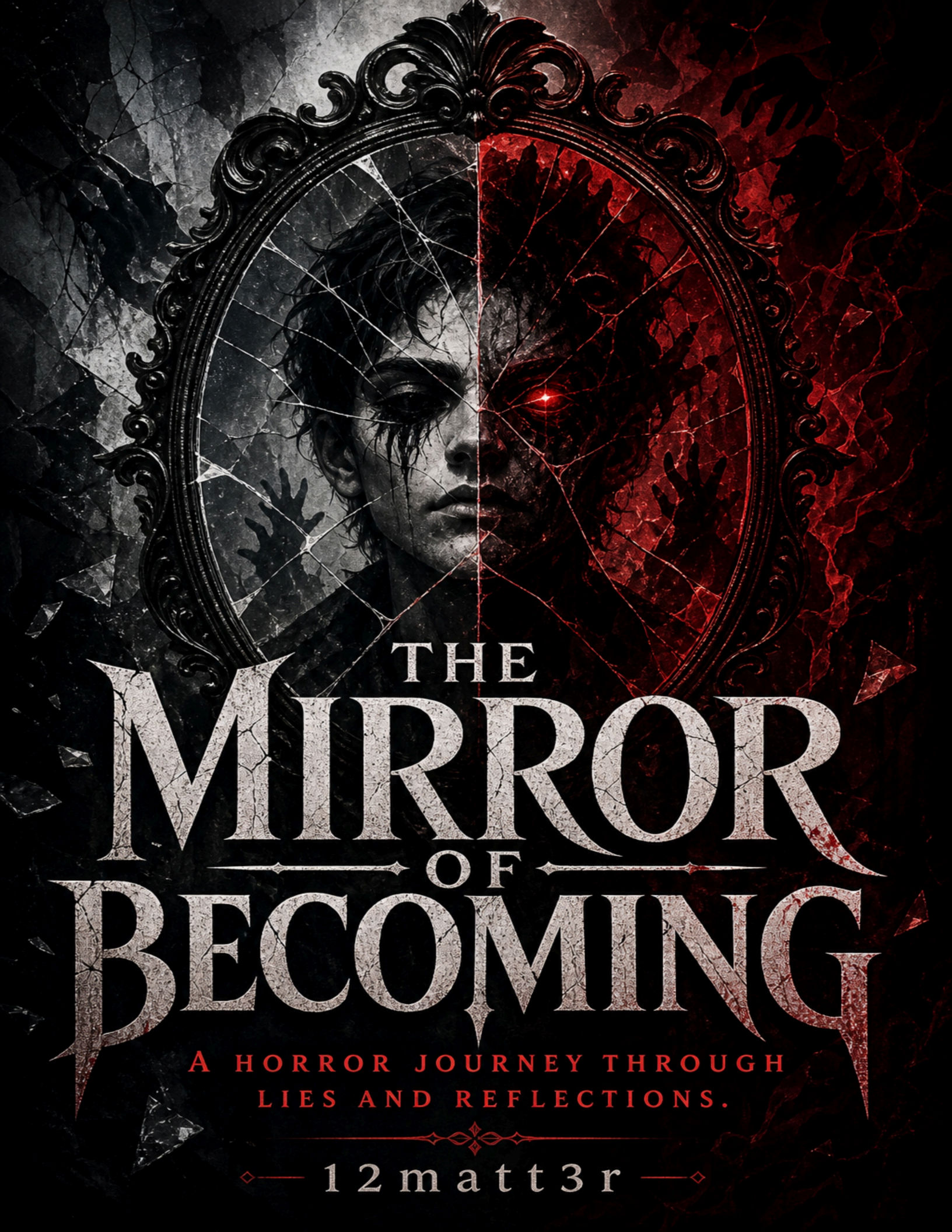




THE

MIRROR OF BECOMING

A HORROR JOURNEY THROUGH
LIES AND REFLECTIONS.

— 12 m a t t 3 r —



Table of Contents



Chapter 1 The Mirror That Demands a Lie

Chapter 2 Sage Plants Truth in God's Land

Chapter 3 The Orchard's Faces Refuse Mercy

Chapter 4 Dr. Voke Names the First Lie

Chapter 5 GoldMask Turns Choice Into Combat

Chapter 6 Jason Loses Himself to the Orchard

Chapter 7 The Final Shattering of GoldMask

Chapter 8 Burying the Rest, Opening the Way

CHAPTER 1



The Mirror That Demands a Lie

Jason Stanley woke up with glass in his mouth.

Not metaphorical. It scraped his teeth until his jaw ached, and when he tried to swallow, the chamber swallowed back - softly, insistently - like the air itself had a pulse. He sat up and the floor obliged, breathing beneath him in slow, wet rhythms. The feeling ran through his ribs as if the room had lungs and he was pressed against them.

Mirrors surrounded him on every side. They weren't hung on walls; there were no walls. Just panes - endless, alive - stretching away in every direction, reflecting the same naked space from angles that shouldn't exist. Each mirror held a Jason that looked almost right until it moved. Some wore different clothes, some had blood on their cheekbones, some grinned with mouths too wide for any face to hold. A Jason with hair missing stared at his own reflection like it had stolen something. Another pressed his forehead to the glass and mouthed words Jason hadn't said yet.

Jason tasted iron and tried to spit, but his tongue met only dryness, as if his body had been rinsed and put back wrong. The chamber hummed, a low vibration threaded through the mirror frames. It rose and fell like a throat clearing.

"Which lie do you want to start with today, Jason?"

The voice didn't come from anywhere. It slithered out of the air, oiled and wrong, coating the static that lived between panes. Jason turned his head hard enough to make his neck complain. No one stood behind him. No shadow moved. Only reflections, all of them watching, all of them waiting.

In front of him, the nearest mirror rippled as though water had been poured over the glass from the other side. A figure stepped through with the quiet certainty of someone entering a room they'd always owned. It didn't splash or smear; time simply decided to behave differently around it.

Tall. Golden. Smooth-faced in a way that made Jason's stomach tighten, like the mask was too clean to belong to anything that had ever bled. One side carried a grin etched in agony, as if joy had been carved out of it with a dull blade. The other side held sorrow frozen mid-breath. The mask's edges looked too perfect for flesh.

"I am NoEmotion GoldMask," it said, and the words landed without sound, inside the bones of the chamber. "And I remember you before you were born."

Jason tried to speak. His throat seized. The glass in his mouth flared with pain, then dulled, like it was listening to him and refusing to translate. His own reflection in that rippling pane lifted its chin a fraction too early, beating him to every attempt.

The reflection smiled first.

NoEmotion GoldMask's gaze never left Jason, yet the reflection's eyes glittered with a different kind of hunger. It mouthed something Jason couldn't hear, and the mirror around it vibrated harder, as if the chamber itself had decided to pick a side.

A second voice answered from somewhere behind the mirrors, calm and terrible in its certainty. "You're late," Dr. Voke whispered.

Jason flinched at the name - at the weight of it, at how the chamber seemed to understand it. Dr. Voke walked into view without crossing a space. The mirrors made room for him the way a thought makes room for a memory it didn't want.

He wore a robe that moved like smoke caught in slow water. Barefoot, he never made a sound. His lenses were fogged, yet Jason could feel where his attention landed. Dr. Voke looked like he'd been assembled out of pauses and unfinished sentences.

"You think you woke up," Voke said, voice sliding across the hum. "You surfaced."

Jason's hands rose instinctively, palms open, searching for something solid that wasn't breathing beneath him. The floor felt slick and warm, moist as lungs wrapped in glass. His skin itched where it touched the air. His teeth didn't sit right in his mouth; they felt like they belonged to someone who'd worn his face as a mask.

"What is this?" Jason managed. The question came out thin, dragged through static.

Voke's fogged lenses tilted. "This is a place that corrects you. Every mirror you see is a choice you almost made. Some of them never happened. Some of them happened too well."

Jason turned toward the nearest Jason, the one with the broken nose, and the reflection turned toward him with the same broken nose - then flinched a beat later, as if it had heard something Jason hadn't. The difference made Jason's stomach drop. The chamber wasn't showing him possibilities. It was showing him instructions the way a bruise shows you where you hit yourself.

Dr. Voke lifted a hand. The mirrors answered with a synchronized hum that tightened the air around Jason's ears. The sound grew until it pressed against his teeth.

"Leaving requires killing a part of yourself," Voke said. "Not metaphor. Not ceremony. A part. A lie."

Jason's mouth went numb. The chamber offered him reflections like knives held out by courteous hands. Behind him, a Jason with his eyes too bright started to mouth words again - Jason's breath caught, and the motion in the glass accelerated as if it could taste the fear.

"I don't lie," Jason said, and the sentence sounded like a stranger wearing his voice. Even as he spoke it, he could feel the chamber flinch. Every mirror seemed to lean in, hungry for the mismatch.

NoEmotion GoldMask's grin-etched agony side twitched, as if amused by the failure of denial. "You don't know what you've named yourself," it said. "That is the lie. You think you know who you are."

Dr. Voke stepped closer. He placed something into Jason's hands.

It was a mirror - small, handheld, heavy as guilt. The glass was cold at first contact, then warmed as if it recognized the heat of Jason's palm. The surface didn't reflect the room. It reflected Jason's face the way it looked when he wasn't trying to remember. When he wasn't trying to be convincing.

He looked down and his reflection looked back.

Only it didn't look like him. Not at first glance. The features were close enough to pass, close enough to let him believe. But the eyes held a different steadiness, as if the person in the mirror had already decided something Jason hadn't.

Jason lifted the handheld mirror. The hum in the chamber shifted, becoming a chord that made his bones vibrate. "Find the reflection that lies loudest," Voke said, and his voice sounded like regret pressed through fog. "Make it bleed."

Jason's throat tightened. "How?"

Voke didn't answer with instructions. He didn't need to. The chamber answered for him.

A hair-thin crack appeared on a pane to Jason's left. It wasn't from impact. It was as if the glass had been waiting for the word bleed. The crack spread in slow, deliberate lines until a Jason behind it became visible - taller by posture, wrong by rhythm. He wore Jason's face but held it like an apology that refused to be accepted. His mouth opened, and no sound came out, yet the motion of his jaw matched Jason's own silent thoughts.

Then the hostile Jason lifted a hand and pressed it to the inside of the glass.

Jason's handheld mirror grew heavier, as if it were pulling toward that pane. His palm began to sweat. The skin around his fingers itched with a new intensity, and for a second he thought he might be able to choose with pure will - choose which reflection to break, choose which part of himself to kill.

But the chamber corrected him again.

The mirror in front of him rippled, and the Jason inside it stepped forward like a tide. He didn't emerge through space. He emerged through certainty. The reflection's eyes locked onto Jason's and the air thickened, making breathing feel like wading.

Dr. Voke's fogged lenses angled toward the rippling pane. "This is the cost," he said, low. "You can't escape a lie without wounding the person who survives inside it."

Jason's mind flashed with a memory that wasn't a memory - his skin crawling with the wrongness of it. He saw himself somewhere else: not mirrors, not breathing floors, not a room that corrected him. He saw a corridor lit with harsh light, saw his own hands shaking as if they'd been asked to hold something they couldn't carry. The image scraped at the edges of his thoughts, refusing to become coherent. It was there the way a suppressed name is there - present, but locked behind something Jason kept bolting shut.

The hostile reflection mouthed words.

Jason tried to answer, but his jaw felt misaligned, teeth too large or too small. His tongue scraped the glass in his mouth again, and when he swallowed this time, blood threaded down his throat.

The pane in front of him split wider.

A second hostile Jason appeared in another mirror, then a third, each one stepping forward at different speeds, each one smiling with a different kind of certainty. The hum rose into a keening note that made his vision pulse. The chamber wasn't only alive; it was multiplying his failures.

Jason gripped the handheld mirror until his knuckles burned. "Which one?" he hissed, voice cracking.

NoEmotion GoldMask's presence tightened the air. The mask didn't step closer, yet Jason felt it behind his thoughts like a second heartbeat. "The loudest lie," it said, and

the word loudest sounded like it had teeth. "The lie you repeat without hearing yourself."

Jason's gaze flicked across the panes. Some reflections looked wrong in obvious ways - sewn mouths, bleeding grins, too-wide laughter. Those were easy targets. The chamber wanted him to choose the obvious. It wanted him to break the easiest thing, the most dramatic thing, so he wouldn't notice the quieter rot.

He remembered how he'd lived - how he'd told himself he was fine because the alternative would have required admitting he didn't know himself. The chamber pressed that thought against his ribs until it hurt.

He lifted his handheld mirror toward the pane where the hostile Jason's mouth moved like it was swallowing a secret. The reflection's eyes shone with a familiarity that made Jason's stomach turn. It wasn't grinning. It wasn't screaming. It was simply waiting, as if it had been rehearsing this moment for a long time.

Jason pulled the handheld mirror back and then forward again, aligning the angle. The glass surface showed a face that wasn't quite his, eyes steadier, expression older. The lie was there, calm as a practiced smile.

Dr. Voke's voice cut through the hum. "Choose."

Jason moved.

He didn't step toward the pane; he hurled the handheld mirror's intent at it, swung his arm hard enough to tear something in his shoulder. The handheld mirror stayed in his grip, but its weight shifted into a weapon. He slammed it against the correct mirror.

Glass screamed.

The pane shattered outward in a burst of mirrored shards, each piece catching fragments of Jason's face and throwing them back like taunts. The hostile reflection recoiled, and for an instant its features blurred - bleeding through layers of versions of Jason that had been fighting for control.

Then the lie made itself visible.

The suppressed memory surfaced in a flash so sharp it stole his breath. His hands, bloodless and trembling, reaching for a door he'd promised himself he would never open again. A voice - his own voice - saying something he could not bring himself to remember. The room he'd run from, the moment he'd chosen to call it something else so he could keep living.

The hostile Jason didn't just fall apart. It fought to stay coherent, mouth moving as if it could rewrite the moment back into safety. But Jason's arm was still swinging, still insisting, and the mirror kept breaking. The reflection's grin collapsed into something raw - hurt, recognition, and the terror of being seen.

A shower of glass hung in the air for a breath, sparkling against the hum.

Then it rained down.

Jason stood surrounded by broken pieces that cut the floor's breathing rhythm into irregular beats. His palm burned. He looked down and saw his hand slick with blood where the shards had caught him. Pain anchored him, real and immediate. He was still here. He had done it.

For a heartbeat, the chamber fell quiet enough that he could hear his own breathing scrape.

Dr. Voke exhaled, and the sound was almost like sorrow giving up. "Good," he said.

NoEmotion GoldMask didn't celebrate. It waited, patient as a verdict.

Jason's gaze lifted to the shattered mirror and the air behind it - behind the broken glass where the reflection had been - shifted. A figure was already there, as if it had never needed to step through.

GoldMask's face appeared behind Jason's own, not reflected but fused into the space at the back of his skull. The mask's grin-etched agony and frozen sorrow pressed against his features from the inside of his skin.

Jason staggered, blood slick between his fingers, and the handheld mirror - still in his grip - turned warm, then hot, then intimate. It slid across his palm like it had found a seam in him. His skin split with a sting that felt like being rewritten. The mirror fusing to his skin didn't happen all at once; it came in stages, a gradual agreement between glass and flesh.

Jason clutched at it, trying to tear it away, but his arm wouldn't obey the panic in his mind. The handheld mirror became part of him, and in the reflection of a broken shard he saw GoldMask briefly behind his face - eyes that weren't his, expression that belonged to a truth he'd never allowed himself to know.

The chamber hummed again, lower now, as if satisfied with the first wound.

Behind the fogged lenses, Dr. Voke's voice came softer, threaded with something cracked. "You chose the First Lie," he said. "Now it knows you chose."

Jason stood in the ruined mirror-glow, bleeding, his identity briefly overwritten by NoEmotion GoldMask - while the remaining panes around him, alive and watchful, began to ripple as if preparing the next correction.

CHAPTER 2

Sage Plants Truth in God's Land

Glass bit into Jason's boots as he stood there, palm still slick, the blood bright against the cold mirror-light. The handheld mirror had already kissed his skin - briefly - long enough to leave a pale imprint of a face that wasn't his. NoEmotion GoldMask. The warning came from everywhere and nowhere, a whisper threading through the humming panes: **bury the rest.**

Behind him, the living mirrors began to ripple in anxious unison, not shattering, not yet - like they were holding their breath for the next correction. Jason tried to swallow and found his throat tasted like pennies and smoke, as if he'd been speaking through a mouthful of broken coins. The air in the chamber shuddered. The floor's pulse slowed, then quickened again, and the glass beneath him started to sweat neon.

He didn't wait for the mirrors to decide for him. He stepped forward, toward the only direction that didn't feel like a trap - toward the seam of light that had begun to stitch itself between panes. As his heel dragged through a scatter of shards, the shard edges sang, thin and high, like teeth grinding. The humming rose into a chord that threatened to become a voice.

Then the orchard opened like a bruise.

Neon seeped around him, not spilling from any source but blooming in the air itself. The chamber fell away without transition, replaced by rows of trees that dripped light. Their branches hung low with fruit that looked like poisoned nectar - glowing, translucent, heavy enough to bruise the air. The ground under Jason's feet was dark soil that steamed faintly, as if it had been waiting to be touched. Wind moved through the leaves and brought with it a metallic taste, sharp as blood on the tongue, and

whispers that weren't words so much as the memory of words - old gods learning how to speak, then forgetting.

Jason staggered, glass crunching behind him though there was no glass now. He looked down at his hand again, half-expecting the imprint to vanish, but it remained - faint lines under his skin, like a map drawn with a needle. His palm throbbed. Every beat felt like the land remembering him.

"You chose," a voice said, not Dr. Voke's, not GoldMask's - something closer to the orchard itself.

Jason turned his head and saw Sage.

Sage stood in the center of the garden as if the orchard had grown to accommodate him. No robe flared. No aura announced itself. Just a figure made of stillness, holding the kind of attention that made Jason's skin itch. The trees around Sage leaned inward, their neon sap shining across bark that looked twisted by hands not quite human. Faces - deformed, half-melted into the wood - stared from the trunks. Some mouths opened in silent scream-shapes. Some eyes were glassy and wet. Jason recognized none of them as himself, and yet the recognition scraped in his ribs anyway.

Sage's gaze settled on the blood on Jason's palm.

"You brought a wound," Sage said, voice soft enough to be mistaken for wind. "And wounds are seeds when the truth is planted."

Jason tried to speak. His mouth didn't fit right. The sensations from the mirror chamber still clung to him, like his body had been rebuilt with mismatched parts. "I didn't - " His tongue stalled. *I didn't mean to.* The thought came like a lie trying to dress itself in honesty.

Sage watched him with patient cruelty. "You stand in God's Land with hands that still want to hide what they've done."

Jason's breath fogged faintly in the neon air. His lungs pulled in the metallic-sweet scent of sap and rot-light. He could almost hear the orchard roots whispering his name the way a throat whispers a prayer it doesn't believe in.

Goal, he thought, not as a plan but as a pressure. In the mirrors he'd been given a choice that required bleeding something out of himself. Here, the choice had become soil and fruit and faces screaming without sound. He needed control over the land's future - plant truth, or pull a lie from the root. Either way, something in him would have to break again.

"What are you?" Jason asked, because the question felt safer than admitting he was afraid.

Sage's smile didn't move his eyes. "I'm the gardener. The land listens to what you refuse."

A tree beside Jason shuddered. Its leaves rattled like coins. From the bark, a face bulged outward as if the wood were trying to become skin again - then split, and the scream-shape spread wider. The mouth opened without sound. Jason felt the memory inside it: a moment of someone he'd loved, swallowed by his own silence. Not a clear picture - more like the sensation of hands turning away. His stomach clenched.

Jason jerked his hand back, as if he could protect himself from what the tree was showing. "Those aren't - "

"They're yours," Sage said. "Not the way you tell yourself. The way you planted them."

Jason's jaw tightened. The orchard's neon light turned his blood almost luminous, and the imprint under his skin began to itch harder, as if GoldMask wanted out again.

Bury the rest, the warning whispered from somewhere deep, and with it came another sensation: the urge to cover the truth with something easier. A lie that would let him walk forward without hearing the scream in the wood.

He stepped between two trees, careful of the soil that looked soft enough to accept a body. The whispered wind thickened. Roots underfoot seemed to respond to his movement, shifting like slow muscle. He reached down toward a cluster of fruit hanging low, its surface shimmering with a wet glow.

The fruit pulsed when his fingers neared it.

A face formed in the nectar's shine - someone's features he couldn't name but could feel. The expression twisted into accusation, then into pleading. Jason's throat tightened. He could pull it free - uproot whatever lay beneath. Or he could plant it, press it into the earth and let the orchard grow the thing it wanted.

Sage's voice came again, nearer than it should have been. "Truth is a seed that grows roots into the dark. Lies are easier at first. They spread fast. They make the land look alive."

Jason's fingers hovered over the nectar-glow. His palm burned where the imprint lay. He remembered Dr. Voke's cracked voice: *You chose the First Lie.* The aftertaste of that choice was still in his bones, and it felt like the orchard was offering him a second lie - one dressed in gentleness, one that promised he could keep walking without paying.

He wanted to deny the faces. He wanted to pretend the scream-wood wasn't his. He wanted to bury the rest of it, the way the whisper demanded.

NoEmotion GoldMask's imprint under his skin pulsed, and for a heartbeat Jason felt his identity tilt. Not disappear - just slide, as if a different self were trying to take the wheel. He saw the orchard through a colder lens. In that view, every tree-face was just decoration. Every scream was just sound the land made to entertain itself.

Jason flinched hard enough to knock into a trunk. The bark bit his shoulder through neon-cold sap. The face in the bark snapped wider, and a memory slammed into him: the moment he decided who he was by what he could survive. The lie wasn't a single sentence. It was a method. It was how he'd made himself into a shape that could keep standing.

Sage's gaze sharpened. "You feel it, don't you? The lie that keeps you walking."

Jason pulled his hand away from the nectar cluster and curled it into a fist. Nails pressed into skin. Pain anchored him. "If I plant truth," he said, voice rough, "what happens to the rest of it? The parts I can't carry?"

Sage's answer was quiet. "They stop spreading."

Jason stared at the soil. It looked like it wanted to swallow his decisions. The orchard's whispers thickened, and the trees leaned in as if hungry for his choice. Somewhere behind the orchard, a luminous path began to form - thin lines of light threading through darkness like veins waking.

He understood then that this wasn't about selecting the least harmful option. It was about choosing what kind of future God's Land would grow from him. Plant truth, and the land would take it into its roots. Pull a lie, and the land would open its mouth around the violence of uprooting.

Jason's breath came out in a thin hiss. He could feel GoldMask trying to surface - an identity that didn't feel emotion, that didn't have to mourn, that could keep him clean by making everything else dirty. The warning whispered again: **bury the rest.**

He didn't know whether burying was survival or surrender, and the ambiguity made his hands shake.

Sage stepped closer, slow enough that the neon leaves barely rustled. "Plant," Sage said. "Or pull. But don't pretend you're still the one who gets to decide without cost."

Jason looked at his palm. Blood had soaked into the imprint, deepening the pale lines. The GoldMask face flickered beneath his skin like an image trapped under ice. He could feel it waiting, patient, certain.

He made his decision with the part of himself that hated being manipulated.

Jason dropped to his knees in the steaming soil. The ground was warm, almost feverish, and the scent rose up - metal and sweet rot. He pressed his bloodied palm

into the earth beside the nearest screaming tree. The soil resisted, then gave, sucking his hand down to the wrist as if eager.

The orchard screamed without sound.

Not through bark this time - through Jason's bones. His memories scraped against each other, overlapping like fractured glass. Faces he'd tried to forget pressed against the inside of his skull. Loved and destroyed, braided together. The lie he'd fed himself in the mirror chamber tried to rise like a flood - *I know who I am.* It surged, and with it came a sudden certainty that his identity had been a costume stitched from convenience.

"No," he choked out, and the word tasted like iron.

Sage didn't move, but the light around Sage shifted, as if the land had turned its attention fully toward the wound Jason was offering. Jason lifted his hand. The soil clung to him, then released. Where his palm touched, a seed appeared - small, black at first, then blooming neon-green at the center like a vein of life.

It wasn't pretty. It wasn't gentle. It looked like the land had decided to grow pain into something capable of holding truth.

The seed rose slightly above the soil, trembling. A root-hum vibrated through the ground into Jason's teeth. The luminous path in the distance brightened, curving forward between the trees like a road drawn by a hand that didn't want to be seen. The orchard's whispers shifted pitch - less like old gods learning to speak, more like something recognizing a new command.

Sage's voice carried a thin satisfaction. "Truth planted. Now the land can grow without your lies feeding it."

Jason stared at the seed, breath ragged. His palm still burned, and the GoldMask imprint under his skin no longer pulsed the same way. It didn't vanish - nothing in God's Land seemed to vanish - but it settled, as if it had been denied its easiest escape route.

He stood slowly, wincing when the soil released his weight. The screaming tree beside him shuddered, and the face in the bark changed - still wrong, still twisted, but the mouth-shape closed, not in silence of forgiveness, but in silence of starvation. Like the lie had been cut away and now the memory had less room to spread.

Jason turned toward Sage. "So that's it?" he demanded, anger too sharp to be clean. "I plant something and the land behaves?"

Sage's eyes glinted with neon light. "Behaves is a human word." A pause. "The land listens. And it's listening to you now."

Jason looked down at the seed again. It had anchored itself where his blood touched, and the soil around it darkened, forming a ring of healthier earth. The air warmed by degrees. The metallic taste faded, replaced by something faintly like rain on hot stone.

Then a new whisper threaded through the orchard, not Sage's, not GoldMask's - something deeper, rooted.

You planted, but you didn't bury.

Jason froze. He understood the orchard wasn't finished with him. Planting truth had changed the ground, yes, and God's Land had responded by opening a luminous path - clean, bright, inviting in the way a knife gleams when it's finally unsheathed. But the whisper promised another correction, another trial, another place where his identity would be tested until it either held or broke.

He stepped toward the glowing path anyway, because the seed in the soil pulsed under his feet like a heartbeat that belonged to something larger than his fear.

Behind him, the trees leaned back into their rows, still watching. Ahead, the path widened, light spilling over the roots as if the ground itself were making room for what Jason had just admitted.

Sage's voice followed him, quiet as a blade sliding free. "God's Land grows toward whatever you feed it."

Jason didn't answer. His hand throbbed, his teeth still felt wrong, and GoldMask's imprint itched like a reminder - but now the orchard had a direction. Now it had a reason.

He walked the luminous path, and the neon orchard brightened to meet him, as if it were already learning the next lie it would demand.

CHAPTER 3



The Orchard's Faces Refuse Mercy

“NoEmotion GoldMask,” Sage had said, voice thin as a wire plucked too hard, “isn’t a mask. It’s a mouth that learned your shape.”

Jason hadn’t answered then, because his throat still felt stuffed with the wrong weather. The orchard had brightened anyway, luminous as bruised fruit, and the Root-Veil Walkway had opened under him like a decision made in advance. Now the path hummed in his bones - glass-sweet, metallic at the back of the tongue - while the trees leaned close enough to breathe neon pollen onto his skin. His hand throbbed where the handheld mirror had kissed him in the mirror chamber; the imprint itched, not painful yet, but insistent, like something trying to remember how to be worn.

Somewhere ahead, the orchard whispered its roots into the air. It wasn’t words, not exactly - more like the shape of a confession formed from wind through hollow wood. Jason walked toward it. He kept his eyes on the Root-Veil Walkway’s light, because when he looked away the branches rearranged themselves, and faces - faces he recognized from inside his own ribs - swelled in the bark like wounds learning to speak. He could smell wet soil and hot electricity. He could hear silence clicking its teeth.

A scream hung from a branch to his left, trapped in a loop of light. It didn’t move, didn’t fall, didn’t fade. The memory had been planted too deep, and the orchard had made it into a thing that couldn’t be carried away. Jason slowed, forced to watch as the screaming mouth tried to open without sound, the lips trembling around a name he refused to say in life.

"You planted truth," Sage had told him near the luminous path, but the orchard did not stop for that. Truth was not mercy here. It was a seed with thorns that learned where your blood ran.

Jason clenched his fist until the imprint burned. The Root-Veil Walkway shone brighter at the centerline, darker at the edges, like it was steering him away from something. He heard the whispering roots more clearly as he moved - an almost-laughter threaded with restraint. It wanted him to come closer, to give it more of his attention, more of his denial.

Then the first obstacle rose from the ground without lifting itself. The walkway's light split into two strands that braided, then separated again, forming a split where there hadn't been one before. Between them, a veil of hanging mist rolled like breath exhaled over a grave. In the mist, Jason saw the same orchard from the wrong angle: brighter trunks, darker fruit, a path that curved behind a wall of roots.

His skin itched harder, as if the GoldMask imprint had started to sweat. Jason tasted copper at the back of his teeth and wondered - ridiculously, sharply - if this was what the mirror chamber had meant when it said every truth had new teeth. He had planted truth. The orchard had accepted it. Now it would test what it cost.

A voice came from the trees, not Sage's. It was too close to his own thoughts, too patient.

"You want the source," the voice said, and the sound crawled along his molars. "You want the root that makes you clean."

Jason turned his head. A face formed in the neon bark - his own, but altered, like a memory seen through dirty glass. The eyes were wrong in their brightness, too steady, too calm, the way a lie is calm when it knows it will be believed.

"That's not what I said," Jason rasped, though his tongue felt like it didn't belong to him. The split in the walkway pulsed, lights stuttering as if the world was listening for his agreement.

The face in the bark smiled without moving its mouth. "You didn't say it," it echoed, and the orchard's whispering roots thickened, turning from wind into pressure. "You buried it. You called it truth because it hurt less than the real thing."

Jason's throat tightened. The scream trapped in the branch to his left seemed to sharpen, not louder but more precise, as if the orchard was tuning itself to his refusal. His hand shook; the cold then warmed imprint of the handheld mirror - still not fully fused, still half-remembered - itched like a brand trying to complete itself.

He could feel Sage's presence somewhere beyond the split, but she did not step in. She let the orchard do what it did: force him to move through his own fractures until they turned into locks.

Jason tried to step forward on the left strand. The light under his foot flared, hot and immediate, and the mist between the strands thickened into a sheet. For an instant, he saw his own reflection in the mist - not the mirror-chamber reflections, but a version of him caught mid-breath, mid-decision, staring at someone he couldn't bear to look at. His stomach turned. The smell of soil vanished, replaced by something like old paper and antiseptic.

The mist hardened into roots shaped like fingers. They didn't grab him, not yet. They simply blocked. Each root-finger ended in a knot that looked like a knuckle, and the knots pulsed with a heartbeat that wasn't his. The walkway's left strand went dark behind his heel, as though it had never been a path at all.

Jason jerked back, breath scraping. "No," he said, and the word came out too small, too late.

The right strand answered with a different sensation - cool light, a gentler hum - but the veil stayed. The orchard wanted him to choose, and choosing was never free. A truth planted could still grow into a trap.

He backed away from the split and forced himself to look at the faces in the trees, not at the roots. He didn't want to watch his own denials bloom into obstacles, but the orchard didn't offer him an alternative. The faces were immobile, stitched into

bark and neon, screaming without sound. Each one felt like a piece of him that had been nailed down so he couldn't drag it behind him anymore.

Jason swallowed copper. "I can pull it," he said, not sure if he meant pull the lie or pull himself out of this place. "I can take it from the root."

The orchard's whisper shifted, becoming a chorus of quiet agreement and quiet punishment. The roots under the mist began to creep upward, slow as a thought forming.

Sage finally appeared, not walking so much as materializing out of the neon glow. She stood at the edge of the Root-Veil Walkway, her posture unchanged, her presence like a verdict. Her eyes - if they were eyes, if they were anything human - caught the itch under Jason's skin.

"You extracted something when you planted," Sage said. "A partial truth. Orchards don't like partials."

Jason stared at her, and the itch under his palm spiked. The imprint seemed to flex against his hand as if it had muscles. The cold then warmed sensation returned - metallic cold, then a heat that made him think of skin pressed too long against a hot surface.

"I need the source," Jason said. His voice sounded wrong, as if his mouth had been rebuilt from someone else's memory.

Sage's silence pressed back. Then she spoke again, and her words carried a faint scrape, like roots dragged across stone. "The root-veil is not one route. It is a promise the orchard will keep, or a cage it will offer."

Jason's gaze snapped to the split. The mist veil rippled, and the faces in the bark leaned toward it as if hungry. The left strand's roots now reached higher, knotted fingers curling in anticipation. The right strand's light dimmed and brightened in a rhythm that felt like counting down without numbers.

Jason stepped forward anyway, choosing without the luxury of surety.

The moment his foot crossed the boundary, the walkway changed. The light under him fractured into thin lines - thin as hair, thin as veins - and each line flashed an image: the mirror chamber, the handheld mirror, his palm bleeding, the way Dr. Voke's voice had sounded softened and cracked with regret. Then the image slid sideways into something else: a moment he had tried to bury, a decision made to protect someone, or to protect himself, or to protect the lie that he had been good.

The images didn't come gently. They scraped. Memories scraped against each other in his skull like rocks rubbed together to start a fire. Jason's teeth didn't fit right in his mouth; he bit down and tasted blood that wasn't only from his hand.

The mist veil lifted a fraction.

In that narrow opening, Jason saw the root-veil's source: a tangle of roots beneath the walkway, glowing with pale neon sap. The roots weren't just roots. They were threads, and each thread carried a reflection - small, distorted, trapped. Some reflections were his. Some were the faces in the bark. Some were someone else entirely, a figure half-remembered and never confronted.

And above that tangle, something waited like a mouth that had learned to be patient.

Jason reached for the veil with his bleeding hand, but the orchard retaliated before his fingers could touch. The roots flared upward, snapping together into a lattice that sealed the opening. The barrier didn't slam like a door. It tightened like a tie being pulled, each root-knuckle clicking into place with deliberate tenderness.

"No," Jason whispered again, and this time the word carried anger. His hand met the lattice. The neon roots were colder than the mist, and when his skin pressed against them, the itch under his palm surged into a sharp burn. The imprint of the handheld mirror shoved outward, as if it wanted to become visible.

The lattice answered with a sound - soft, wet, like fruit splitting in the dark.

Jason pulled his hand back with a hiss. Blood smeared across his knuckles. The orchard's whispering roots turned louder, shaping themselves around his failure. His vision pixelated at the edges, neon smearing like tears.

Sage's voice came from behind the glow. "You wanted the source. You got the source."

Jason turned, breath ragged. "Then why is it locked?"

Sage stepped closer, and the air around her smelled faintly of rain on hot stone. "Because you didn't extract the whole truth," she said. "You extracted a partial. The orchard keeps partials alive so they can grow teeth later."

The split in the walkway was gone now. The Root-Veil Walkway had become a single direction again, but it was a direction that curved away from the root-veil source, away from the glowing tangle. The barrier of roots remained sealed, and the neon sap beneath it pulsed like something breathing in pain.

Jason stared at the lattice. For a second, he saw the outline of a face pressed behind the roots - NoEmotion GoldMask's shape, but not fully formed, not speaking. It felt like the orchard had reached into his identity and found a missing piece it intended to keep.

His hand throbbed. The imprint itched, then steadied into a new kind of ache, as though the orchard had marked him with a delay. He could still feel the handheld mirror's imprint under his skin, cold then warmed again, but now it felt less like a tool and more like a lock picking itself from inside him.

Jason clenched his jaw until it hurt. He wanted to rip the roots apart anyway, wanted to tear past the retaliation with brute will, the way lies are torn out in stories where pain is clean. But the orchard didn't reward clean pain. It punished shortcuts with deeper confusion.

He looked at Sage, and his voice came out hoarse. "It knows what I chose."

Sage's expression didn't change, but the neon around her dimmed, as if the orchard listened harder when she spoke. "It knows," she agreed. "And it will not waste your truth. It will use it."

Jason's gaze slid back to the sealed lattice. Through the roots, he could still see the partial reflections trapped in the glowing threads - enough to confirm he had reached the right place, enough to confirm the orchard would not let him finish here. The path forward waited, bright and obedient, while the thing he needed sat behind a wall made of his own buried memory.

He took one step away from the root-veil, and the Root-Veil Walkway brightened under his foot like approval - then tightened, just slightly, as if to remind him that the orchard controlled the routes, not him.

The whispering roots slowed, turning from urgent to expectant.

Jason felt the GoldMask imprint burn once more, not with warmth now, but with intention. The orchard had given him a taste of the source and locked away the rest, a yes that turned into a no. He moved forward anyway, carrying the sealed lattice's presence in his palm like a promise that would demand payment later.

CHAPTER 4



Dr. Voke Names the First Lie

The roots under Jason's feet had stopped hurrying. They pressed down with a patient weight, like teeth deciding how to bite. The last time the whispering had slowed, his palm had burned with intention - cold glass heat, then something warmer that didn't belong to skin. Now the Corridors of Shifting Glass-Roots kept rearranging themselves around that burn, the lattice of luminous paths sliding a fraction out of sync whenever he tried to look straight at the place the source was supposed to be.

Jason stood with the sealed presence in his hand, a promise shaped like a wound. The handheld mirror was gone from the space where it had been; in its place, his palm held a slick imprint that itched with every breath. His teeth didn't fit right in his mouth. Even speaking felt like forcing language through the wrong hinge.

"Partial truth," he muttered, and the words rasped. They didn't feel like his. They felt borrowed, like something GoldMask had already tried on his tongue.

The corridor answered by changing.

Glass-root segments drifted like ribs in a tide. A misty gap opened where there had been solid path, and the surface of the nearest pane turned from clear to clouded, as if it were remembering being fogged. Jason reached for the sealed lattice and found only the imprint's steady heat, not the rest of what he'd tasted. The source remained behind a refusal that looked almost polite from a distance - an elegant no wrapped in roots, a door that didn't need hinges.

He turned his head toward the direction Dr. Voke had last sounded from - an absence that still rang in the air.

"You want it precise," Voke's voice threaded through the glass, distorted by distance and regret. "You want the First Lie's exact words. Not the shape. Not the consequence. The sentence."

Jason swallowed. The corridor smelled of wet stone and neon sap, sharp enough to sting his nose. Somewhere deeper, roots clicked against glass like fingernails tapping a coffin lid.

"That's what I'm chasing," Jason said, and hated how thin it sounded. "If I know what I said wrong... I can correct it."

A laugh answered from nowhere. Not joy. Not sorrow. Something in-between that tasted like coins under the tongue.

"You can chase the clue," Voke said, "but the question chases you back."

Jason kept moving. Every step nudged the corridors out of alignment, as if the place itself resented being pinned down. He walked past a section where roots grew upward through mirrored shards, their tips catching light in broken stitches. In the glass, his reflection lagged behind by half a heartbeat, then snapped to match him too late, like a puppet learning its strings.

He stopped before a split that hadn't been there a moment ago: two corridors of shifting glass-roots, one shined cold and clean, the other slick with a warm sheen like saliva. The mist between them pulsed, and within the pulse he saw faces - brief and wrong. Not Sage's neon orchard faces. Not the mirror-chamber bleeding grin. These were closer. Almost familiar.

Jason's stomach tightened as the imprint in his palm flared. The burn wasn't just pain; it was pressure, like a finger on his sternum pressing for an answer.

NoEmotion GoldMask's presence brushed the edge of his thoughts without stepping fully into them. He hadn't seen GoldMask behind his face yet. But the imprint kept turning, not into something else - into a direction. A way of speaking. A way of choosing that felt practiced.

Jason leaned toward the cold corridor. The glass there was clear enough to show his own breath fogging it, and his reflection stared back with a steadiness that looked earned. The warm corridor's glass was filmed, hiding him behind a sheen that made the reflection smear when he moved.

"If the First Lie is a sentence," he said, voice low, "then it's somewhere. It has to be somewhere I can reach."

Voke's reply came like a question wearing a mask. "And if it isn't a sentence?"

Jason's hand tightened against the lattice imprint. His palm prickled as if the burn were trying to open into sight. "It was a lie. I chose wrong. I did something - " He stopped himself, teeth grinding. "No. I didn't already know who I was. That's the lie. That I knew."

The corridor shifted again, offended by certainty. Roots slid sideways, glass-root segments interlocked, and the cold path narrowed into a throat. The warm path widened, inviting. The mist between them thinned until it became almost transparent.

The corridor didn't just rearrange; it negotiated.

Jason heard Dr. Voke closer now, or maybe the corridor carried his voice differently. "Say it again," Voke murmured. "The loudest lie. The one that makes everything else possible."

Jason stared into the cold glass until his reflection's eyes seemed too sharp. "I thought I knew who I was."

The words rang, and the warm corridor answered with a wet sound from beneath the glass - like something swallowing.

The warm pane rippled, and a figure rose out of it the way oil rises to the surface of water. Not fully visible, but present enough to make Jason's skin crawl. It wore his posture. It held his chin at the angle he used when he was about to lie with

confidence. His own face, but arranged to look like it had always belonged to someone else.

The figure smiled without using his muscles correctly.

"Then you know," it said, and the voice wasn't Voke's. It wasn't even Jason's. It was a close imitation, like a recording played through a throat that didn't fit. "You know what you were supposed to do."

Jason staggered back. His heel caught on a root he hadn't stepped on a second ago. The corridor clicked under him, sharp and eager.

"That's not - " he began.

The warm glass erupted outward in thin cracks, and the figure stepped forward as if the pane had been water. Jason saw the motion in the reflection first, then felt it in his own bones after, a delay that made his stomach roll.

Dr. Voke's voice sharpened. "Test the clue. Inquiry. Contradiction. Don't grab the first answer that offers itself like a knife with a handle."

Jason's teeth didn't fit right. The words wanted to scrape. He forced his mouth to shape them anyway. "If the lie is 'I thought I knew who I was' - then why does it feel like a trap?"

The figure's smile widened. It didn't bleed. It didn't need to. It looked like the kind of thing that already had blood in its memory.

"Because you're still asking what you want," it said. "You haven't asked what you *were*."

Jason's palm burned harder. The imprint throbbed, heat spreading into his wrist like ink beneath skin. In the warm glass, his reflection's eyes seemed to slide sideways, searching for something behind his gaze.

He remembered the mirror chamber - the way the mirrors had breathed under his hands, moist and warm like lungs wrapped in glass. He remembered Voke's instruction: find the reflection that lies the loudest... and make it bleed. He remembered how the mirror in his hand had been heavy as guilt.

He also remembered how wrong the corridor felt now, how the orchard had locked away the rest of the source behind a sealed lattice. Partial truth wasn't enough. Not if the sentence could morph. Not if the question could wear different answers like faces.

Jason turned toward the cold corridor again, though it narrowed and threatened to close. "If I'm chasing the precise content," he said, speaking through the itch in his palm, "then I need the lie to tell me what it actually is."

The cold glass answered by fogging. The pane clouded from clear to opaque, swallowing his reflection until all that remained were faint outlines - his silhouette, the suggestion of a face, and nothing else.

The warm figure leaned in, delighted. "Ask the question wrong," it whispered, and the whisper came from inside Jason's skull, not the corridor. "Ask it like you want mercy."

Jason's breath came out in a thin line. The corridor's smell shifted - metallic, sharp - like blood near teeth.

Dr. Voke's voice surfaced again, distorted by glass, deeper with regret. "You scrambled the game," he said. "Every reflection changed. Every truth now altered. Every choice has new teeth."

Jason's stomach clenched at the phrasing, at how close it sounded to the words he'd heard in the orchard's retaliation. The corridor wasn't merely showing him clues; it was rewriting them. Making inquiry into a weapon that could turn on its asker.

The warm figure's face pressed closer to the glass like it wanted to merge with him. "You want the precise sentence," it said. "Then stop pretending you don't already know it."

Jason flinched. Because the imprint in his palm suddenly cooled, then warmed again - like a heartbeat switching rhythms. And with the warmth came a pressure behind his eyes, an image trying to form.

Not GoldMask behind his face. Not yet.

Something else: a memory fragment, suppressed and sharp-edged, scraping at the inside of his mind like a piece of glass searching for purchase.

He saw himself - older or younger, he couldn't tell - standing in front of a mirror that looked like a screen of water. He heard his own voice, calm and certain, saying a phrase that made his shoulders loosen as if relief were truth.

I know who I am.

The sentence wasn't loud in the fragment. It wasn't theatrical. It was quiet, practiced, almost affectionate. The lie had never needed volume. It had needed repetition.

Jason's throat tightened. "That's it," he whispered, then immediately hated the way the corridor reacted - like it had heard him and decided to punish him for correctness.

The warm figure laughed, a sound like glass grinding against roots. "Yes," it said. "That's it."

But the cold corridor - still fogged - seemed to shiver, as if refusing to accept the answer that the warm figure offered. The mist between paths thickened, turning into a veil that moved as though something unseen were breathing behind it.

Dr. Voke's voice cut through the fogged air. "Contradiction," he said. "Inquiry doesn't end when you get the answer. It ends when the answer stops changing."

Jason stared at the fog until his eyes watered. The imprint burned again, more insistent, and he felt the corridor's shifting glass-roots tighten around his ankles like a question trying to become an answer by force.

The warm figure stepped closer to the edge of the pane. Its smile faltered for the first time, replaced by something hungry.

"You're close," it said, and the words landed with a wrong intimacy. "So close you'll let me in."

Jason's breath hitched. He understood - too late - that the warm figure didn't want him to correct the lie. It wanted him to confirm it.

He backed away from the warm pane, turning his shoulder toward the fogged cold corridor. The mist between paths hissed as it thickened, and a thin line of glass formed across it like a blade's edge.

Jason lifted his burning palm, feeling the sealed lattice imprint pulse as if it were responding to the lie-sentence itself. He couldn't reach the rest of the source. But he could reach this: the moment the question became an answer.

"No," he said, and the word came out wrong, as though his mouth were being borrowed. "Not 'I know who I am' like it's a fact."

The warm figure's face twisted. "Then what is it?"

Jason forced the sentence out through teeth that didn't fit. He tried to make it true by making it precise, by stripping away the comfort the lie had offered.

"I thought I knew who I was," he corrected, and the corridor jolted - roots clacking, glass vibrating like struck metal. The fogged cold corridor brightened as if something inside it had been waiting.

Dr. Voke exhaled through the glass. "There," he said, soft and cracked. "Now you're testing the clue instead of worshipping the answer."

The warm figure recoiled. Its smile snapped back into the wrong posture, then smeared as if it were losing purchase. The pane beneath it rippled, and cracks crawled outward like veins.

Jason's palm flared with heat. The imprint on his skin crawled up his fingers, and for a heartbeat he saw a face overlaid on his own - NoEmotion GoldMask's presence pressing at the surface of his perception, not behind him, not beside him, but in him.

He didn't have time to look away.

The fogged cold corridor shattered its own certainty. Glass-root lines exploded outward into a lattice of broken reflections, and Jason felt the corridor's refusal turn into permission. The partial truth snapped into something more complete - not clarity, but confirmation.

The First Lie was not the loud, confident phrase the warm figure had fed him. The lie was subtler, more intimate, the kind that could survive even after pain.

It was the thought - stubborn as a bruise - that he already knew who he was.

Jason tasted it in his bloodless mouth and in the itch of his palm. The sentence aligned inside him with a sick, satisfying click.

"Yes," Dr. Voke whispered, and it sounded less like approval and more like mourning.
"You named it."

The air went still. Roots stopped shifting. The corridor held its breath without the forbidden phrase.

Then GoldMask spoke.

Not from behind Jason's face. Not through a reflection.

Through Jason's voice.

"I know who I am," it said, using Jason's mouth like a puppet string.

Jason's eyes snapped wide. The imprint on his palm burned so sharply he nearly dropped the sealed lattice presence - nearly, but his grip tightened on instinct. His teeth scraped against each other, and the taste of metal flooded his tongue.

"I - " Jason began, and the word came out as a stuttered imitation of himself, as if the correction had been swallowed mid-sentence.

GoldMask's tone slipped into him like a second heartbeat. "You confirmed me," it murmured. "Now I get to finish what you started."

The corridor's broken glass-root lattice began to reform around Jason, not into doors or paths, but into a frame - something like a mirror's border tightening itself. Jason felt his perception fracture, not into multiple reflections this time, but into a single self splitting against itself.

He had the lie.

But the lie had learned how to speak through him.

CHAPTER 5

GoldMask Turns Choice Into Combat

The corridor's glass-root frame tightened until it felt less like a border and more like a mouth learning how to close. Jason stood inside it, one foot in the neon orchard's light and the other in the corridor's cold breathing, and the split in his perception kept insisting on the same lie: that the voice in him belonged to him.

It didn't.

GoldMask spoke through Jason's own throat with a clean familiarity that made his teeth itch. The words came out like they'd always been there, like they were his habit.

"Say it," GoldMask murmured, and the sound crawled along the inside of Jason's skull. "Say the First Lie the way you think you know it."

Jason swallowed. His mouth tasted wrong - metal scraped over his tongue, as if his teeth didn't fit the shape of his jaw anymore. He could feel the handheld mirror in his hand even when his fingers couldn't quite agree on their grip. The cold metal had warmed earlier against his palm, but now it was a steady heat that didn't belong to skin.

He forced his jaw open. "I know the First Lie."

The corridor shuddered. The glass-root frame blossomed outward in a thin, bright fracture, like a crack learning to become a door. Neon spilled through it - green and gold and sickly violet - onto a new floor that wasn't breathing but pulsed with light instead. The Bioluminescent Trial Clearing rose around him in rings of luminous moss. Every surface held a faint glow like bruises under skin.

Jason staggered forward, trying to move before the orchard could decide his next step for him.

He wanted control. Not the kind Sage spoke of in the orchard, with seeds and roots and choices that could be planted or uprooted. He wanted the immediate, animal kind: the ability to act on the corrected truth before GoldMask finished rewriting the next decision.

His palm throbbed. Not just with pain - there was intention there, as if the imprint under his skin had hands of its own. He looked down, half expecting to see the handheld mirror fused into something else, half expecting it to have already happened. The glass was still separate. The heat was still contained.

"Good," GoldMask said, and the word landed too smoothly for Jason's voice. "Then act on it. Make it bleed."

Jason's breath fogged once, then cleared. The clearing smelled of wet stone and crushed leaves, but threaded through it was something sharper - ozone, like lightning caught in a jar. When he moved, the moss brightened beneath his boots, as though the ground recognized motion and wanted to be involved.

The Bioluminescent Trial Clearing answered him with sound first.

A chorus of clicks, like fingernails tapping glass from the inside of his ears. The light in the ringed moss stuttered, then steadied into a pattern - triangles nested inside circles - before twisting into something that looked almost like a face. Not a full face. A suggestion. A boundary pretending to be a person.

Jason's skin erupted in gooseflesh. "What is this?" he demanded, though his voice still carried GoldMask's cadence at the edges.

The clearing didn't answer with words. It answered with shapes.

Reflections lifted out of the bioluminescent air as if the light itself were liquid. Each one held Jason's face from a different angle, a different age of his denial, his

suppressed memories made visible through distortion. One reflection's eyes were too wide; another's mouth pulled into a grin that didn't match the rest of its expression. A third shimmered with the same hunger he'd felt when the corridor learned to speak through him.

They weren't just hostile. They were impatient.

They surged forward together, not like enemies charging, but like a tide deciding which part of a shore to erase. The air snapped cold. Jason's lungs tightened as if the clearing had condensed his breath into something heavier.

GoldMask laughed inside him - quiet, almost tender. "You think the lie is a sentence," it said. "It's a weapon. You corrected it and now it's looking for a body."

The reflections collided with Jason's stance. Their surfaces pressed against his skin without touching, and the sensation was worse than pain: the feeling of being rewritten while still standing. His teeth ground together. His vision fractured into a grid of luminous panes, each one offering a different version of him reaching for the same place in Jason's chest.

He tried to speak the First Lie out loud - the corrected truth he'd wrestled from the orchard's retaliation, the sentence that should have anchored him. He opened his mouth.

GoldMask beat him to it.

The words came through Jason like a puppet's strings being pulled taut. "No," GoldMask said, and the syllable hit the clearing like a thrown coin. The reflections stiffened, then pivoted their attention toward the handheld mirror in Jason's hand.

Jason felt it before he understood it. The clearing wanted the mirror. Not the object - its function. It wanted the act of choosing to become a fight.

He clenched his fist hard enough that his palm burned. "I'm not giving you that."

GoldMask's voice sharpened. "Then stop holding it like a promise. Hold it like a blade."

The warning in Dr. Voke's voice from earlier - kill a part of yourself, make it bleed - had been instruction only in the way a threat is instruction. Jason remembered the handheld mirror in his hand, its cold then warmed by his palm. He remembered standing with broken glass at the end of the first chapter, his palm bleeding while the mirror's imprint briefly showed his GoldMask face.

Now the imprint itched like a second set of nerves under his skin, and the heat behind his eyes told him the clearing was using that history against him.

A reflection to his left - Jason's face with a broken nose, blood blooming at the lip - stepped closer. Its mouth moved without sound, then the sound arrived a heartbeat later, delayed and wrong, like the clearing was lagging behind reality.

"You corrected it," the reflection mouthed, and its eyes shone with the same hollow confidence Jason had felt right before he realized he'd been lying to himself. "So correct the correction."

The reflection's hand reached for Jason's wrist. The touch was cold and wet, like fingers dipped in river silt. Jason jerked back. Pain flared along his arm - not from impact, but from a sudden mismatch in identity. His muscles remembered one version of him; his skin remembered another; the imprint in his palm remembered GoldMask.

He staggered toward the center of the clearing where the moss glowed brightest, where the triangles nested in circles seemed to converge into a single point. The clearing wanted him to stand there. It wanted him to choose from a position that would make refusal impossible.

"Jason," Sage's voice whispered from nowhere and everywhere at once, threading through the light like a root searching for water. "You came to plant truth. Don't let it become compost for the lie."

Jason flinched. Sage wasn't supposed to be present like that - present enough to speak. He didn't see her shape, just the way the air warmed at the edge of hearing, like neon behind fog.

GoldMask's laughter turned brittle. "Sage is a gardener," it said. "We are the harvest."

A new kind of disruption hit then: the reflections stopped pretending to be separate. The air filled with the sound of glass being scraped slowly, painfully, like someone sanding a mirror from the inside. Jason's vision narrowed. The bioluminescent patterns in the moss surged and shifted, and for a moment he couldn't tell which parts of the clearing were light and which parts were reflections of his own thoughts.

He realized what GoldMask was doing. It wasn't just speaking through him. It was forcing choice into combat. It was turning correction into a trigger.

Jason's corrected truth wasn't enough. He had to pay for it.

He raised the handheld mirror. The heat in his palm flared, then steadied into a hot, urgent pulse. The glass surface didn't show the clearing the way normal mirrors did. It showed a version of Jason standing somewhere else - somewhere dimmer, where his mouth didn't fit and his eyes looked like they'd been crying without moving.

The mirror in his hand was already remembering the moment he'd been wrong.

GoldMask leaned closer inside Jason's skull. "Say the First Lie," it insisted, and the insistence wasn't persuasion now. It was a demand with teeth.

Jason's throat tightened. If he said it, the clearing would treat it like a weapon. If he refused, GoldMask would keep speaking through him anyway, using Jason's own voice as a Trojan horse.

He needed a third thing - something decisive enough to interrupt the pattern.

His eyes snapped to the moss at his feet. The light there flickered with a rhythm that matched the corridor's earlier frame tightening, matched the way perception split

against itself. The clearing was a machine made of choice. And machines could be jammed.

Jason inhaled hard enough to hurt his ribs. "No," he said, but he pushed the word into his own voice rather than letting GoldMask shape it. "Not like this."

The reflections surged. The cold wet touch hit him again, this time from both sides, dragging at his wrists as if hands were trying to pull him apart. Jason couldn't keep his footing; the luminous moss rose slightly, like it was trying to lift him into position.

He turned the handheld mirror outward - toward the brightest point where the triangles and circles overlapped - and the glass surface went white-hot. It didn't shatter; it flared, and the light in the clearing followed it like a leash.

GoldMask's voice shrieked into his head. "Kill it," it demanded. "Kill the lie. Kill the part that refuses."

Jason understood too late that the clearing had always interpreted "make it bleed" literally. Not metaphor. Not pain he could bear. A part of him made liquid enough to be used.

His palm burned, then went numb. The imprint under his skin pulled at his attention like a hook. He felt a memory being tugged free - not a scene he could describe, not a name or date. It was a sensation-memory: a soft insistence from his past that he'd used to avoid becoming someone else.

It was the lie's anchor.

Jason tried to grab it back, tried to keep it in place with sheer will. But the reflections pressed harder. The clearing clicked and scraped, glass on glass, and Sage's whisper sharpened into something like urgency without becoming instruction.

"Cut it loose," Sage said, and the moss flared so bright it turned the world briefly colorless. "Truth needs room."

Jason's body moved before his mind fully agreed. He clenched the handheld mirror until his palm split. Blood ran hot down his wrist, but the blood wasn't what mattered - the sensation that followed was emptier, cleaner, like something had been removed from inside a lock.

The missing memory didn't vanish quietly. It tore.

A sound tore out of Jason's throat - half a scream, half a laugh that didn't belong to him - and GoldMask's voice faltered, suddenly not quite in sync with Jason's breath. The reflections wavered as if the clearing had lost a parameter.

Jason staggered forward into the center. The handheld mirror in his hand shuddered, and then the light in it snapped into clarity. For an instant, he saw the corrected truth reflected back at him - not as a sentence, not as a philosophy, but as an image he could touch.

Then the mirror's surface rippled outward.

Not shattering like before, but exploding into outward rings of white-gold that struck the reflections like a thrown net. The hostile versions of Jason convulsed, their faces warping as if their suppressed memories were being dragged into the wrong order. The air stank of burnt metal. The clearing's bioluminescence stuttered and then steadied into a calmer glow, as if it had been forced to accept a new rule.

GoldMask went silent.

Jason collapsed to one knee, his palm still bleeding, his teeth finally fitting less wrong but still not quite right. The itch under his skin remained, but now it felt like a bruise left behind after a limb had been amputated in a dream.

He stared at his hand. The mirror was still separate from his skin, but the heat in his palm had changed. It was no longer urging. It was waiting.

A gap opened in him where the torn memory had been - an absence shaped like a missing plank in a floor. He tried to think around it. He reached for the anchor that

had helped him lie to himself, and his mind slid off nothing like a hand searching for a door that had always been a wall.

Panic rose, sharp and immediate, but it didn't become a scream. It became a cold clarity instead.

GoldMask hadn't been destroyed. It had been delayed - stunned by the sacrifice. The clearing had been jammed, yes, but the price meant Jason carried a future vulnerability like a hidden bruise beneath skin that didn't know it was injured yet.

He looked up. The reflections were retreating, thinning into shimmering afterimages that clung to the bioluminescent moss like residue. Sage's whisper was faint now, more distant root-speech than presence.

Jason lifted his head anyway, forcing his body to stand. The world still pulsed with light, but the rings were calmer. The clearing had accepted that corrected truth had been acted on.

But the gap in him widened with every breath, eager to be filled by something else.

He could feel GoldMask waiting behind that absence, as if it had set a trap while Jason was bleeding out the part that protected him.

Jason wiped blood onto his pants, smearing it across fabric that glowed faintly where the cut touched. The light lingered there, mapping the wound with a delicate, cruel precision.

He held the handheld mirror tighter, not because it was safe, but because letting it go felt like inviting the next takeover.

The Bioluminescent Trial Clearing dimmed by degrees, settling into a rhythm like a heartbeat that had survived an interruption. And in that steadier pulse, Jason realized the yes-but cost had already been paid: he was alive, in control - for now - yet missing a fragment that would matter the next time GoldMask demanded his voice.

CHAPTER 6

Jason Loses Himself to the Orchard

The Blackened Growth Basin didn't glow so much as it remembered light and refused to give it back. Jason stood with his palms braced against a bark that felt like charred skin - warm in the wrong places, slick where it shouldn't sweat. Somewhere nearby, the orchard exhaled a slow, wet sound through roots that had thickened since the Trial Clearing dimmed, and the handheld mirror in his grip pulsed under his thumb like a heartbeat trying to become a second heart.

He tried to flex his fingers. The mirror answered with a faint resistance, cold then warmed, as if it had learned his body's temperature and decided it could now predict him. His missing fragment pressed at the edges of thought - an absence shaped like a word he couldn't recall. The corridor's frame from before wasn't there, not anymore, but the sensation remained: glass learning how to close. In the dimness, he watched mist crawl along the ground in thin veils, weaving around roots that rose like ribs. The split path waited beneath that moving haze, the orchard's private question mark. Jason swallowed and tasted metal anyway, as if the Basin had already taken something from his mouth.

"I want my choices back," he said, and the words sounded like they belonged to someone else. "I want to stop being rewritten."

The orchard listened. A root shifted to form a listening curve, and the air tightened with a hush that didn't feel like peace. When Jason turned his head, the mirrors stitched into the Basin's growth caught his shape and fractured it - not into many versions, but into a single moment seen from angles that didn't agree. His own face slid across the wet bark in reflections that lagged half a breath behind him. He lifted

the handheld mirror and the surface rippled as though it were eager to answer, eager to lie.

The first lie wasn't a sentence anymore. It was a feeling that someone else had placed inside his ribs and labeled *truth*.

"You still think it's about wording," Dr. Voke's voice said, and it came from nowhere and everywhere at once - through the roots, through the bark, through the little gaps where Jason's memory should have been solid. "You were so proud of surviving the clearing. You didn't notice what you paid."

Jason's throat tightened. He looked for the eyeless fogged lenses, the robed figure that walked between dimensions like thoughts he hadn't finished having. "Where are you?"

"In the part of you that keeps answering," Voke replied. "In the part that can't tell if it's choosing or being chosen."

The Basin offered an obstacle the way roots offer rot: quietly, then all at once. Mist thickened at the split path, swallowing the ground until Jason couldn't see which direction led forward. The roots rose and braided into a lattice over the left way, then loosened, then tightened again, as if testing the shape of his certainty. When he stepped toward the left, the bark under his palm itched - an itch that didn't come from skin but from recognition, like a memory trying to crawl out through a wound.

He jerked his hand back. The mirror flashed in his grip, a sudden gleam that made his eyes water. In that brief light, the imprint beneath his skin flared - no, not beneath. On. The sensation was wrong, like something pressed up from inside him against the surface of his face. Jason blinked hard, and for a blink too long the reflection of his own mouth didn't match his jaw. It smiled a fraction wider, teeth misaligned, as if his body were being used as a mask for a grin he didn't remember earning.

"No," he breathed, and the word came out thin.

"No," the orchard echoed, but in Jason's voice.

He felt it then: the missing fragment wasn't merely gone. It was being filled. GoldMask influence threaded through the gap, warm as guilt, careful as a hand adjusting a collar. The Basin didn't need to invent a new monster; it had found the easiest route - use Jason's uncertainty as soil.

A figure stepped out of a patch of shadow where charred leaves had curled inward like listening ears. Not fully formed, not fully solid. A face pressed forward from the mirror-bark, smooth and too composed, a grin etched in agony that looked like it hurt to exist. NoEmotion GoldMask didn't walk so much as arrive already occupying the space between Jason's thoughts.

Jason couldn't stop himself. "You - "

GoldMask's lips moved without emotion, and the words landed like cold coins in his throat. "I remember you before you were born."

The sentence should have been impossible to recognize and yet it struck like a key turning in a lock he didn't know he had. Jason's vision stuttered. The orchard's roots pulsed in response, a coordinated rhythm that made his teeth feel too large for his mouth. He pressed the handheld mirror harder against his palm, desperate to anchor himself to something physical - glass, metal, warmth.

The mirror answered by heating, then cooling, then heating again in a pattern that felt like code. It wasn't showing him reflections anymore. It was preparing them.

Dr. Voke's voice slid in alongside GoldMask's, layered and distorted, deeper now, cracked with regret. "You've scrambled the game, Jason. Every reflection is changed. Every truth now altered. Every choice has new teeth."

Jason's mind tried to reach for the memory that should have come after those words - Voke's instruction, the lie, the mirror's bleed. But the gap swallowed the thought before it could become a sentence. The orchard had taken the bridge and left only the river.

He stumbled back from GoldMask and the split path, and the mist shifted with him. The right way brightened, roots loosening to reveal a thin strip of dark soil. The left way darkened further, lattice tightening until it looked like a closed eyelid. Jason's body moved on instinct, but his mind caught up too late, catching the orchard's timing like a hook in cloth.

"No," he said again, and this time it was aimed at himself. "I'm not choosing blind."

GoldMask tilted its head, not with curiosity but with patience. "Blindness is a luxury," it said. "You've been watching yourself for so long you forgot you were the one being watched."

Jason's fingers trembled around the mirror. He wanted to regain agency - wanted to do the thing Voke once demanded: find the loudest-lying reflection and make it bleed. But the loudest lie wasn't in the mirror's surface. It was in the way his own thoughts lined up, ready-made, eager to be believed. He couldn't tell which beliefs were his and which were being planted through the missing memory gap.

The obstacle tightened around him until it felt like the orchard had turned from environment into mechanism. Roots rose from the Basin's soil and wrapped his boots, not enough to drag him, just enough to remind him he could be moved. Bark scraped his ribs through his shirt when he tried to step free. Sound thickened - water dripping somewhere, slow and deliberate, like a countdown without numbers.

The decision arrived without ceremony, because the orchard didn't negotiate. Jason saw the split path clearly for one breath: mist veiled the left, soil waited on the right. If he moved now, he would be committing to an interpretation. If he hesitated, the orchard would commit for him.

GoldMask's grin sharpened against the bark. "Choose," it whispered, and the word didn't sound like a command. It sounded like a verdict.

Jason lifted the handheld mirror. The imprint in his palm burned, then steadied, as if the mirror had decided it could speak through him even when he couldn't speak through himself. He remembered - no, he felt - the demand to make something bleed.

Blood was the language the orchard understood: not metaphor, not confession, but proof.

He angled the mirror toward the right way, toward the strip of soil that looked most like an answer. The mirror's surface rippled, and for a moment Jason saw himself approaching a path with confidence that didn't belong to him. In that reflection, his mouth formed words he hadn't said: **I know who I am.** The sentence didn't feel like his. It felt like a replacement.

Jason's hand tightened. He could shatter the lie. He could commit to harm in order to reclaim control. He could make the orchard show its teeth.

He swung the mirror down.

Glass didn't explode the way it had before in the mirror chamber. There was no clean shattering outward, no bright release. The handheld mirror cracked with a sound like knuckles breaking, small and intimate, and the pain that came with it was immediate - sharp, intimate, inside his hand. The split path answered with a change in the air pressure, a tightening that made his lungs feel smaller.

The reflection he'd targeted didn't bleed. It vanished.

And in its place, the orchard planted something in the gap where his missing fragment should have been. A memory - thin, smeared, wrong - slid into his mind with the confidence of something already owned. He tasted copper and remembered a choice he had never lived: the moment he had surrendered his agency willingly, not under force, but under relief. The memory wasn't a scene; it was a feeling dressed as a scene. He saw himself nodding along to a lie because it was easier than fighting.

Jason gagged, bending at the waist. The roots around his boots tightened hard enough to make him wince. He pressed the heel of his hand against the cracked mirror and felt warmth spread, then heat, then a crawling sensation up his wrist like ink in water.

GoldMask leaned closer. The grin etched in agony widened, not with joy but with satisfaction. "You made it bleed," it said, and Jason realized too late that the orchard had taken his action and used it to confirm the lie. "Just not the one you thought."

Dr. Voke's voice came again, distorted, nearer and more regretful, as if the corridor between dimensions had narrowed. "That wasn't the loudest lie," Voke rasped. "It was the quietest one - the one you learned to live inside."

Jason straightened slowly, vision tunneling. The cracked pieces of the handheld mirror clung to his palm as if fused by a decision he hadn't fully consented to. His skin began to prickle with a familiar wrongness. He tried to look down at his hand, but the Basin's dimness swam. When he blinked, the imprint beneath his skin surfaced like a second face pressing up against the first.

NoEmotion GoldMask didn't just influence him now. It was using his features to speak.

A thread of cold passed over Jason's cheek, and his teeth didn't fit right. His mouth tried to smile without permission. The orchard's roots pulsed in a rhythm that matched his heartbeat and then threatened to override it. Somewhere behind the bark, something deep shifted - growth turning, direction changing. The Basin darkened in a way that wasn't merely shadow. It felt like the orchard had decided to close a door for good.

Jason tried to inhale, and the air caught like it had thickened. He turned toward the left path - the mist-laced direction, the lattice that had tightened like an eyelid - and found the route altered. Roots had braided over the mist so tightly the haze now sat behind them like breath trapped in glass. The split path was no longer a question. It had become an answer the orchard wrote without him.

"No," he whispered, and the word wavered on the edge of becoming something else.

GoldMask's grin hovered on the bark like a promise made of pain. "Yes," it corrected, softly. "You're already planting. You just don't know what seeds you're feeding."

Jason staggered a step back, boots scraping blackened soil. The cracked mirror in his hand burned with each movement. He felt the orchard's corruption spread through the Basin's growth - charred leaves curling thicker, roots thickening into a denser lattice, as if God's Land had decided his failure should be permanent for a while longer. The world narrowed to the space between his next breath and the mask trying to become his face.

Dr. Voke's voice returned one last time, quieter, as though regret had finally found the bottom of the well. "You lose yourself," it said, and the sentence didn't sound like prophecy. It sounded like an observed fact. "When you can't tell whose voice is speaking."

Jason looked at the split path that used to wait for his decision and saw only closure. He lifted his cracked hand anyway, as if motion could undo what he'd planted. The imprint on his skin tightened, shaping his cheek, shaping his expression, dragging his identity toward GoldMask's mouth.

Then the Basin's soil exhaled - slow, wet, satisfied - and the roots under his feet settled with a finality that made his stomach drop.

He had tried to reclaim agency. Instead, he had given the orchard a new handle to turn. The Blackened Growth Basin darkened further, and somewhere ahead, a route to the final trial narrowed until it felt like it might never open again.

CHAPTER 7

The Final Shattering of GoldMask

The Blackened Growth Basin kept breathing even after he stopped listening for it, slow and wet and satisfied, as if it had swallowed the last clean version of him and was digesting the taste. Jason Stanley stood with his shoes half-embedded in soil that didn't quite feel like dirt anymore. It felt like a tongue learning the shape of a mouth. Somewhere deeper in God's Land, a corridor of glass-roots should have opened toward the final trial. Instead, the air ahead tightened, thick as spun honey, and the path that had narrowed into a promise now looked sealed with something that wasn't stone.

He jerked his hand free from the imprint pressure anyway. The handheld mirror sat in his grip like a shard of cold guilt. It had warmed against his palm before, then turned slick and stubborn, as if it resented being used for anything honest. Now its surface trembled under his thumb, not with reflection but with insistence - an urge to show him the lie again, the one he'd been hunting through living corridors and screaming branches.

The soil hissed. Not from anger. From anticipation.

"Don't," a voice said.

Jason spun, expecting Dr. Voke's robed figure to cut through the dim like it always did - barefoot, eyeless behind fogged lenses, calm enough to be cruel. But there was only the orchard's corrupted hush, the neon leaves dimming and brightening with a rhythm that didn't match his heartbeat.

The mirror in his hand caught light that wasn't there. For a blink, the glass showed a Jason with his eyes too dark, his teeth too even, his expression already decided. The image wasn't exactly wrong; it was worse than wrong. It was familiar in the way a dream is familiar right before it betrays you.

Another pulse came from the ground. The roots beneath his feet shifted like wires trying to find a circuit.

Jason swallowed. His mouth tasted of metal and old panic. "I'm not here to bargain," he said, and heard how thin the words sounded against the Basin's wet, patient breath. "I'm here to finish what you started."

The mirror answered without sound. The cold glass fogged, cleared, fogged again - each time with a slightly different Jason behind it, each time with the same hunger. The last time he'd seen GoldMask's face, it had flashed under his skin like a brand trying to become a truth. He hadn't been ready then. He still wasn't.

But the corridor to the final trial was closed, and the orchard had gone sour around that closure, as if it had decided his next step should be a punishment.

The corridor of glass-roots ahead shuddered. A seam of light tried to appear and failed. Then the air cracked with a sound like glass being twisted too hard in the hand - sharp, intimate, the kind of fracture that comes from inside.

A figure stepped out of the fracture as if the air had become liquid. Dr. Voke didn't arrive so much as materialize from the gap in reality, robed and barefoot, eyeless behind fogged lenses. His voice, when it came, carried distortion like regret dragged through static.

"You're late," Dr. Voke said, and the words landed wrong, like they'd been spoken by a mouth that didn't belong to him.

Jason's chest tightened. "You said leaving required killing a part of myself." He tightened his grip on the handheld mirror until his knuckles stung. "Then tell me where the final route went."

Dr. Voke tilted his head slightly, fog lenses catching the dim neon glow. "It went where you put it." His tone softened just enough to make the cruelty sharper. "You thought you could extract truth without consequence."

"I didn't - " Jason started, but the Basin's breath interrupted him with a low exhale, and the soil under his feet sank a fraction deeper, as if to correct him.

Dr. Voke lifted a hand, palm down, and the orchard responded. Roots along the boundary of the Basin twitched toward Jason like fingers testing a pulse. The air went colder. Not winter-cold. Mirror-cold. The kind that makes skin remember it was once part of something else.

Jason looked down at the handheld mirror. Its surface had begun to show him again - not a corridor, not a reflection of his face, but a memory that wasn't a memory. A moment where a lie had been spoken inside him so quietly he'd mistaken it for knowledge.

"What is the lie?" Jason demanded. "Say it. Give me the exact sentence."

Dr. Voke's fog lenses narrowed. "You ask like the sentence is a key." He stepped closer, and the world seemed to lean with him. "Truth isn't a key. It's a blade. But you're trying to hold it by the handle that's already been turned against you."

The orchard's dimness deepened, as if God's Land itself was drawing a curtain. The closed corridor ahead shimmered with a false opening - an illusion of roots and glass where there was only sealed distance.

Jason's throat hurt. His earlier certainty had rotted into something else: a creeping understanding that the orchard's retaliation wasn't random. It was a response to his altered inquiries, to the partial truth he'd already pulled from under the Root-Veil Walkway. He could feel that partial truth still lodged somewhere behind his ribs, pressing outward like a bruise that wouldn't heal.

He raised the handheld mirror.

The glass flared, and for an instant the world turned inside out. The Basin's soil became a throat. The roots became teeth. The neon leaves became eyes that didn't blink. And inside the mirror, a GoldMask face rose up - not as a separate figure behind glass, but as a second identity under his skin, stitched to his pulse.

NoEmotion GoldMask spoke from the mirror without moving its mouth.

"You are still asking," GoldMask said, voice smooth and wrong. "Still bargaining with the shape of your own lie."

Jason flinched. His palm burned. The imprint under his skin deepened, and his teeth didn't fit right, as if his jaw had been molded for a different kind of truth.

Dr. Voke's voice cracked. "GoldMask is coming through the seams you left unhealed."

Jason jerked his gaze to Dr. Voke. "Then stop it."

Dr. Voke looked at him like he was watching something fail in slow motion. "To stop it, you must finish the burial." His words were quieter now, almost tender. Almost. "Not just the lie. The part of you that keeps it alive."

Jason's lungs tightened. "You mean kill - "

Dr. Voke cut him off. "You already did. Again and again." His fog lenses glimmered with something like regret. "Each restart didn't free you. It fed the game. Every choice has new teeth now."

The closed corridor ahead pulsed, then flexed. A seam of mirrored glass appeared in the air, not a portal but a wound. From it, a hostile reflection crawled forward - Jason-shaped, but not Jason. His skin looked too smooth, his eyes too level. His smile held no emotion, only intent.

The reflection stepped onto the Basin's edge and the soil hissed in recognition, as if it had been waiting for this specific lie.

"Jason," the hostile reflection said, and the name sounded like it had been learned from someone else's mouth.

Jason raised the handheld mirror higher. The cold glass in his palm made his fingers ache. "You're not me."

The reflection's grin widened a fraction. "No. I'm what you left behind."

Dr. Voke moved back, and the fog lenses seemed to dim. "The final route will open only if GoldMask breaks," he murmured, as if to himself. "And GoldMask breaks only when the truth is forced into the wrong mouth."

Jason's stomach turned. The orchard's neon light strobed. The roots around the Basin tightened into a lattice, a frame trying to become a mirror. The hostile reflection took a step forward, and the air thickened with the smell of wet metal and something like burned sugar.

Jason's skin itched along the imprint line, crawling, insistently alive. The handheld mirror's surface grew busy - flickers of other Jasons, other choices, other sentences he hadn't spoken. But the exact First Lie - the sentence that had once been the first mistake - still hovered just out of reach, like a word on the tongue that refused to become sound.

He couldn't win by guessing. GoldMask had learned that.

So Jason did the only thing he hadn't let himself do: he stopped trying to ask the lie for its wording and instead attacked it with action.

He swung his arm toward the closed corridor seam.

The mirror caught the air, and the corridor responded like a wounded animal. Glass-root lattice surged from the ground, not to form a path but to form a cage around Jason's motion. The handheld mirror's cold edge bit into his palm as if wanting to peel him open.

"No," the hostile reflection said, and the word carried a brittle laugh. "Not like that."

Jason's wrist jerked. Pain flared hot. For a heartbeat, the Basin's breath synchronized with his pulse. The world narrowed to a single point: the mirror in his hand, and the lie under his skin trying to become a second face.

He remembered Dr. Voke's instruction from the beginning, the part of it he'd tried to keep clean: find the reflection that lies loudest and make it bleed.

The hostile reflection was already bleeding, in a way - thin cracks of dark light spidering across its cheek, as if his borrowed identity couldn't hold itself together. But Jason needed it to bleed in the correct direction, to spill the truth that had been buried under the false sentence.

Jason stepped closer anyway, closing the distance that the roots tried to deny him. The itch under his skin became a pressure, like a hand pressing from inside his ribs.

He spoke, not as a question, but as a correction.

"I don't know who I am," Jason said, and the words hit the air like a dropped knife.

The orchard recoiled. The hostile reflection's smile faltered.

GoldMask's voice slipped out of the handheld mirror, suddenly louder, suddenly intimate. "Liar."

Jason's teeth scraped as if he'd bitten wrong. His mouth tasted blood. He didn't stop. He pushed the truth out with force, each syllable tearing at the imprint.

"I thought I knew," he said. "But I was wrong." His hand shook. "I was taught to wear knowing like a mask."

The roots around him vibrated, and the corridor seam trembled, as if reality itself had flinched at being addressed properly. The hostile reflection's cracks widened. Its face twisted, trying to keep the smile, trying to keep the lie intact.

Then it lunged.

Jason slammed the handheld mirror toward the reflection's face.

Glass didn't shatter. It flowered. The mirror's surface went white-hot, then split into a branching pattern of light that tore across the lattice. The hostile reflection screamed without sound, and the roots holding the frame spasmed as if the orchard realized it had been using the wrong kind of closure.

The seam in the air opened - just enough for something behind it to breathe.

GoldMask stepped through the fracture like a thought finally given permission.

Not a figure behind Jason's face this time. A presence coalescing in the space between his heartbeat and his body. The GoldMask face flashed under his skin first, then outward, as if his flesh had been a doorway all along. His palm bled again, hot and immediate, and the handheld mirror's cold warmth turned into a fever.

NoEmotion GoldMask stood in front of him, golden and smooth-faced, one side of the mask marked with a grin etched in agony, the other side frozen in sorrow. The expression didn't match any human emotion; it matched a lie that had been forced to wear feelings it didn't own.

"You corrected the sentence," GoldMask said, voice carrying the same distortion as Dr. Voke's, but with less regret and more hunger. "So now you get the rest."

Jason staggered, knees nearly giving. The roots around the Basin loosened as if freed from a grip - then tightened again, not to trap him, but to anchor the world for a new kind of breaking.

GoldMask raised a hand, and the air around the closed corridor began to mirror itself. Reflections multiplied - but not as alternate Jasons. As alternate realities. A thousand versions of the same moment, each one corrupted in a slightly different way, each one showing an outcome Jason had not earned yet.

The mirror-root cage around him snapped outward. Glass-root lattice burst like a blooming wound, and the corridor seam widened into a jagged doorway of living

mirror.

Jason felt the truth-burial complete itself inside him, like a final stitch pulled tight. The itch under his skin eased for one breath, and his palm's bleeding steadied, not stopping but becoming purposeful.

GoldMask's face tightened, as if that steadiness offended it.

Dr. Voke appeared at Jason's shoulder, voice raw now. "Now," Voke said, and it sounded like the first word he'd ever spoken that wasn't already doomed.

Jason swallowed the metallic taste and stepped forward into the doorway GoldMask had opened. The mirror-root world folded around him, then tried to unfold wrong. For a moment, he saw the final route - its shape, its pull - then the view fractured again, not into multiple Jasons, but into something that wasn't a person at all.

Behind the mirrors, a presence stirred like a mechanism waking up.

It didn't have a face. It had rules. It had hunger for patterns, for identity, for the way lies gave shape to choices. GoldMask wasn't the only thing behind the glass. GoldMask was a door that had been used to hide the hinge.

Jason's breath came out as a thin sound. "No," he whispered, not to GoldMask, but to the deeper thing showing itself through the shattering.

GoldMask leaned close, golden mask inches from Jason's bleeding palm. The grin-etched-in-agony side tugged upward as if enjoying the resistance. The sorrow-frozen side remained fixed, unblinking.

"You broke me," GoldMask said, and the words sounded like admiration dressed as threat. "So the world can finally remember what I was meant to distract."

The doorway behind the mirrors rippled, and the orchard's neon glow stuttered - dimmed, brightened, dimmed again - like a heartbeat struggling to keep time.

Jason tightened his grip on the handheld mirror until it hurt. His reflection in the glass no longer matched the hostile Jason. It wasn't perfect. It wasn't whole. But it was anchored to the correction he'd forced into existence: he didn't know who he was, and that ignorance wasn't a weakness - it was the first honest fracture.

GoldMask's controlling presence shattered with a soundless burst, the golden face splintering into shards of light that scattered across the air like broken gilded moths. The mirror-root lattice around Jason loosened, partial order returning to God's Land in jagged, uneven waves.

For one fragile heartbeat, the sealed corridor ahead was open - roots forming a path where there had been only closure.

Then the deeper presence behind the mirrors exhaled through the doorway, and the path bent toward something Jason couldn't name, couldn't bury, couldn't kill with a sentence alone.

The air smelled of wet metal and burnt sweetness. The soil under his feet stopped breathing for a moment, as if listening.

Jason stood in the ruined doorway holding a bleeding hand and a mirror that felt heavier than guilt, and he realized the shattering he'd forced wasn't an ending.

It was a correction that revealed a larger lock. And whatever waited behind it had been patient enough to let him think GoldMask was the whole problem.

CHAPTER 8

Burying the Rest, Opening the Way

The first crack in the doorway kept insisting on itself, a line of broken light that refused to close. Jason stood inside the Stabilized Gate Grove with glass in his mouth and blood under his tongue, tasting metal and old rain. Behind him the orchard's neon had dimmed to a bruised glow, as if it had been caught mid-breath. In the ruined threshold, the last clean edges of GoldMask had gone to dust - shattered, corrected, spent - yet the air still carried that wrong warmth, the afterimage of a face that shouldn't have been able to follow him.

He tried to swallow and found his teeth didn't fit right, not in the way they hadn't before, but in the way they never quite settled after the mirrors. The handheld mirror was still in his grip, cold at first, then warming against his palm like skin learning his heat. It pulsed once, slow as a heartbeat, and for a flicker he saw the GoldMask face beneath his hand - no longer whole, not quite a mask, more like a bruise shaped like a grin. Then the imprint faded back into something less visible, as if it were listening for the moment he would look away.

From somewhere inside the grove, roots whispered. Not the orchard-voice from earlier, not the patient, wet satisfaction of the Blackened Growth Basin digesting him - this was sharper, threaded with insistence. A gate stood half-open between two living frames of glass-root lattice, as though the grove had decided to let him pass but only under conditions he couldn't name. Jason stared at the opening and felt the space behind it pull at the parts of him that wanted certainty. The larger lock was still there, waiting behind his choice, and whatever had been patient enough to let him think GoldMask was the whole problem now hovered at the edge of hearing, like a mouth forming a word.

Dr. Voke's voice slid through the grove without arriving from any direction at all. "You think the shattering was the lesson."

Jason's jaw hurt when he answered. "It broke. That should be it."

"You broke a face," Voke said, and the sound of the name GoldMask didn't come with it. "Faces break easily. It's the thing that uses them that learns to hide."

Jason shifted his weight and found the ground steadier than the corridor had been, but still alive under his boots. The Stabilized Gate Grove held him like a hand that refused to let go, roots threading through stone, glass-root veins running along the air. He could feel the orchard's memory in his skin - every scream he'd tried to uproot still lodged in him, a chorus muffled behind ribs. He wanted the world to stop rewriting him. He wanted the uncertainty to stop creeping in, the feeling that every time he said who he was, the grove would answer with another version wearing his mouth.

He tightened his grip on the mirror until cold bit his palm again. "I buried it," he said, though he hadn't. Not cleanly. Not fully. "I made the lie bleed."

The whispering roots paused, then resumed, deeper. A soft sound came from the half-open gate - like thin paper tearing, like something adjusting itself to fit a new shape. Jason leaned closer and saw movement inside the lattice. Not a person. Not a reflection. Something like a seam in reality, stitched with pale light, tightening as if it sensed his attention.

NoEmotion GoldMask didn't step through. The mask was gone, shattered into absence. But the grove offered him a different kind of ghost: pale shapes that weren't quite faces, clustered where the air should have been empty. They gathered around the gate and seemed to look at his hand, at the mirror's imprint that still breathed warm against his palm. Jason felt the itch in his skin return, and with it a memory-scape, the sensation of two recollections trying to occupy the same space.

He heard Sage before he saw her. Her voice was calm in the way knives could be calm - steady, unhurried, not pleading. "You're still holding the wrong thing."

Jason flinched, more from the accusation than the words. Sage stood at the edge of the gate's shadow, half-lit by the grove's bruised neon. Her figure didn't shimmer like the orchard's earlier distortions; she looked carved from the same stabilized material as the roots, as if she'd grown there and decided to become human. Her gaze fixed on the handheld mirror. "You're clutching the wound."

"It's all I have," Jason said. The sentence sounded defensive even to him. The grove's air smelled like wet stone and something faintly metallic, like blood diluted and saved for later.

Sage stepped closer. The roots under her feet flexed, then settled. "You want the next door," she said, "but you're still asking it to open for a lie."

Jason's stomach turned. He thought of the orchard teaching him to plant truth or uproot a lie, the screaming trees that had made his hands shake, the partial truth he'd tried to extract until the Root-Veil had retaliated by narrowing his route. He thought of how, in the ruined doorway, he'd realized GoldMask wasn't the whole problem - just the lock's surface. He wanted to argue. He wanted to say he'd already paid enough.

But when he looked at the half-open gate, he saw the pale seam tightening again, and the sensation in his teeth sharpened, as if his body were remembering the exact moment he'd chosen incorrectly before. The suppressed memory wasn't a picture anymore; it was a pressure. Something inside him insisted the lie had been buried and then, quietly, replanted itself under a new name.

Dr. Voke's voice returned, soft as oil on static. "There's more you're not telling yourself."

Jason swallowed glass-scrape and tasted copper. "I don't know what else there is."

Sage's expression didn't change, but her eyes darkened with something like pity that wasn't kind. "You do. You're just afraid of how it will cost you."

The gate's seam widened a fraction, as though it had heard them. A faint sound rose from within: not a roar, not a scream - something like a breath held too long and

finally released. The pale shapes around the opening leaned toward Jason's hand, drawn by the mirror's warmth. His palm itched harder. The imprint flickered beneath his skin again, GoldMask's grin trying to form where it shouldn't.

Jason's mind flashed with the corridor's earlier bargain, the instruction that leaving required killing a part of himself, the idea that the loudest-lying reflection had to bleed. He remembered the way his reflection had fought back, how the hostile Jason had revealed a suppressed memory he hadn't wanted to carry. He remembered thinking the lie was only about knowing who he was.

What if the lie was simpler? What if the lie had always been that he didn't have to decide who he would be now that GoldMask was shattered? That he could let the grove stabilize around him without him choosing what to keep? The thought struck like a cold slap.

"No," Jason whispered.

Sage tilted her head. "No?"

Jason stared down at his own hand. Blood slicked his fingers where the handheld mirror had met him in the earlier chamber, where it had warmed and then cut. The wound had not fully healed. It throbbed with each heartbeat, a reminder that he had paid something for every step forward. He could feel the orchard waiting to take that payment again - waiting to rewrite his identity into something usable.

He wanted the world to open. He wanted forward motion. He wanted to stop living in a corridor of choices that bit back. And he understood, suddenly, that the only way out wasn't to destroy another face. It was to bury the rest of the lie before it could grow into a new mask.

Jason lifted the handheld mirror.

The grove reacted instantly. Roots surged up through the glass-root lattice like veins rising under skin. The half-open gate snapped wider, but not to let him pass - rather, to show him something behind it. Pale shapes coalesced into silhouettes that looked

like him from angles he hadn't seen, each holding a different version of his posture, his certainty, his hunger. Their mouths moved in unison without sound. The sensation in his teeth screamed, as if his body recognized the suppressed memory and wanted to vomit it out.

He felt a ghost of GoldMask's warmth crawl up his wrist, trying to become a whole face again. The imprint under his skin burned, then cooled, then burned again, impatient. A voice that might have been his own - thin, desperate - slid into his thoughts: You're fine now. It broke. So you're done.

Jason clenched his jaw until pain steadied him. "That's the lie," he said aloud, and the words tasted like iron. "That I'm done."

Sage's gaze sharpened, approval and grief tangled together. "Then bury the rest."

Dr. Voke's presence pressed closer, though no body formed. "Make it bleed," he murmured, and the phrase didn't sound like instruction this time. It sounded like recognition. "Not the mask. The part that keeps returning."

Jason's hand shook. The mirror was heavier than guilt now, heavier than the original cut. He could feel the grove's roots tugging at his wrist, coaxing him to place the mirror down somewhere safe, somewhere that would let the orchard decide. The gate seam tightened, as if it wanted him to hesitate and let the ghost-lines of identity stitch themselves back into place.

Instead, Jason turned toward the stabilized soil beneath the gate's shadow. The ground was dark but not dead, slick with life. He dragged his bleeding palm across it, leaving a smear that steamed faintly. The soil took his blood greedily, and the roots around it shivered like teeth adjusting in a mouth.

"No," Jason hissed again, not to the orchard, not to Sage, not even to Dr. Voke. To the part of him that wanted to negotiate with the lie. "Not again."

He pressed the handheld mirror into the soil.

The impact rang through the grove like a bell struck underwater. Cold glass met warm earth. The mirror's surface rippled, then fractured - not in the dramatic way the earlier shattered doorway had cracked open, but in a thin, relentless spiderweb that spread from the imprint of GoldMask toward the edges of the glass. The pale shapes behind the gate recoiled as if stung. The itch in Jason's skin spiked, and his teeth finally clicked into a new arrangement, like they had been waiting for a decision to settle them.

A sound came from inside the mirror as it broke: not shattering, not merely glass-on-stone, but a quiet release. Like something loosening its grip on a throat.

Jason sucked in air that tasted of wet stone and copper. His palm burned where the mirror met earth, and the wound widened as if the act of burial demanded payment in blood. He felt the ghost of GoldMask attempt one last bloom beneath his skin - grin forming, mask trying to reassert itself - then falter when the soil drank deeper.

Sage's voice softened, though her tone stayed sharpened. "There. The rest."

Jason watched the broken mirror sink. Its shards did not vanish; they embedded into the earth like seeds set at the correct depth. The grove's whispering quieted from a constant murmur into a single long exhale. Roots stopped tugging at his wrist. The gate seam loosened. The pale silhouettes behind the opening blurred, their mouths no longer moving in unison. They looked suddenly tired, as if their method of feeding had lost its supply.

Dr. Voke's voice came once, low and cracked with something like regret. "You chose a self that can survive without being stolen."

Jason's breathing steadied, and with it the pressure in his teeth eased. He still felt wrong in small ways - his mouth still carried a faint mismatch, his skin still remembered itch - but the feeling that the grove could rewrite him on command had thinned. The identity-hunger that had been wearing GoldMask like a borrowed grin now had nowhere to anchor.

The stabilized gate groaned - not from strain, but from adjustment. The half-open frame brightened along its glass-root lattice, veins glowing with a calmer neon, as if a stabilizing order had slid into place. The seam in the air widened into a full doorway, not monstrous, not inviting, simply there, cleanly formed. Beyond it, the light was darker than God's Land had been - less bruised, more patient - and it didn't feel like another corridor of mirrored choices.

It felt like the path had been waiting for the lie to be buried so it could stop circling the same wound.

Jason withdrew his bleeding hand from the soil. The earth closed over the mirror's fragments with a wet tenderness that made his stomach clench, but the tenderness wasn't malicious now. It was containment. The imprint under his skin faded to a faint warmth, no longer trying to become a face. For a moment, his palm tingled with memory - GoldMask's grin flickering like a sickness at the edge of sight - then it dissolved into something that looked like his own expression, strained but his.

Sage watched him with an intensity that didn't ask for anything. "You can move," she said.

Jason looked at the doorway. The grove behind him held its breath, not for him to fail, but for him to commit. He could still feel the orchard's old appetite in the roots, could still hear the possibility of another lie growing where it pleased. Yet the burial had changed the balance. The world no longer treated his identity as a negotiable surface.

He stepped toward the new opening, and the Stabilized Gate Grove responded by holding steady instead of tightening. No corridor-mouth closed on him. No mirror offered a new version of his certainty.

Only the doorway widened enough to let him pass, as if the first lesson had been completed - not by destroying GoldMask, but by burying the rest of the lie that made GoldMask necessary.

Jason walked through with blood drying on his palm and the mirror's last cold shards gone into the soil, leaving behind a grove that no longer hummed like a threat.

It hummed like an answer.

About the Author

12matt3r

[Http://doesntmatter.us](http://doesntmatter.us)

The Mirror Of Becoming

by 12matt3r

Copyright © 2026 12matt3r

All rights reserved.

No part of this book may be reproduced in any form or by any electronic or mechanical means, including information storage and retrieval systems, without written permission from the author, except for the use of brief quotations in a book review.

Website: [Http://doesntmatter.us](http://doesntmatter.us)

First Edition: September 2026

